

What else to watch: *The Wild One* (1953) ■ *À bout de souffle* (1960, pp.166–67) ■ *Pierrot le Fou* (1965) ■ *Woodstock* (1970) ■ *Kings of the Road* (1976)

mire in drug binges and shouting matches. Fonda even threatened to abandon the project. But it may be that very anarchy that made *Easy Rider* an icon of its time. Hopper felt he was part of a revolution. The disorganized nature of the project was a rude gesture of rebellion.

The rough cut is said to have run for over three hours. Hopper chose to cut out story details to leave behind a series of loosely linked images and moments, held together by a pounding sound track.

West to east

In some ways, the two bikers seem like modern-day cowboys, riding off to find freedom, and their names Wyatt (Peter Fonda) and Billy (Dennis Hopper) recall the Western heroes Wyatt Earp and Billy the Kid. In fact the bikers are nothing so noble. Rather, they are a pair of

drifting drug dealers heading east because there's no longer a Wild West. Their bike bags are stuffed with money made from selling drugs to Mr. Big, and when they are joined by a sharp-suited drunken lawyer (Jack Nicholson), he ends up seeming far more rebellious than them. The title conveys an image of chilled-out bikers, but it actually comes from the slang for living off the earnings of a prostitute.

Easy Rider's bleak violence ensures that the movie is no hippy trip, but rather an incoherent blast of frustration. In reality, it signaled a disillusioned end to a previous generation's idealism. ■

Wyatt and Billy hide the cash they've made from drug smuggling in the stars-and-stripes-adorned fuel tank of a chopper, and head to New Orleans for Mardi Gras.



Dennis Hopper
Director/Actor

A multit talented actor, writer, director, and photographer, Dennis Hopper carved out a name for himself as one of the wild cards of Hollywood. Born in 1936 in Dodge City, Kansas, he showed early promise as an artist, but was soon drawn to acting and studied at the Actors Studio in New York under the legendary Lee Strasberg. He initially made his name with television work, but it wasn't until he directed and starred in *Easy Rider* that he became a celebrity. In later years, Hopper's problems with alcohol and drugs stalled his progress, although he did direct and star in the excellent punk drama *Out of the Blue*. Eventually, after entering a rehab program in 1983, his career took off again with riveting performances in such movies as *Blue Velvet* (pp.256–57), and numerous Hollywood bad guy roles. Hopper died in 2010.

Key movies

1969 *Easy Rider*
1979 *Apocalypse Now*
1980 *Out of the Blue*
1986 *Blue Velvet*

